

ON THE JOB
Tapesh Mathur with a cow that received a prosthetic, in Rajasthan's Pali district

SHIPRA MATHUR

INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Let animals be safe from man-made road accidents so that they are not disabled. I would love it if no animal required a prosthetic, but if they do, let us take responsibility to help them"

— DR TAPESH MATHUR

Helping animals *find their feet*

A Rajasthan veterinarian makes prosthetics to give disabled animals a second chance

By **ROHIT PARIHAR**

In 2014, Dr Tapesh Mathur was posted at the Hingonia Cow Rehabilitation Shelter in Jaipur following rising cases of animal deaths there. The veterinarian would perform at least one surgery a day to help cows that had consumed plastic. While his efforts helped bring down fatalities, Mathur realised the need for prosthetics for cows that had suffered accidents and lost limbs. "Animals do survive after the amputation of a limb but, in a good number of cases, a prosthetic makes things easier and extends their lifespan," he says.

Mathur soon started making prosthetics for animals, under the brand 'Krishna Limb', named after the first cow that received an artificial limb from him. He has to date provided 160 prosthetics, mostly free of charge, across the country. That has required travelling to 16 states to do the job, beginning with taking measurements for the cast and finally fixing the prosthetic and getting the animal up on its feet. The travel time on each project, he says, itself runs into a week, besides days spent at the prosthetic workshop that he has set up at his modest home in Jaipur. When the pandemic struck and movement was restricted, Mathur took to video calls to get the cast measurements through local veterinarians and guiding owners on handling their animals after the prosthetic had been fixed.

Mathur says that to be able to use a prosthetic, the amputation should leave as long a bone intact as possible. But more than that, the animal owner needs to be patient and sensitive as getting an animal mobile on a prosthetic requires time and training. Besides, the artificial limb needs to be removed after seven to eight hours of use, cleaned and refitted the next day. Mathur says many people approach him thinking that a prosthetic is a permanent solution that will free them from the added responsibility of caring for a disabled animal. The vet takes a written assurance from those ultimately going for it that they will continue to take care of their animal.

TAPESH MATHUR, 50
A veterinarian with the Rajasthan government
Jaipur

Mathur's work has mostly helped cows but he rues that many *gaushalas* lack dedication in caring for the animals. There are positive experiences as well, such as a calf having prosthetics in both front limbs walking well. Then, in Bikaner, Mathur fitted an artificial limb on a cow and persuaded the owner to take her back home from the *gaushala*. In Hyderabad and Jaisalmer, pregnant cows that received artificial limbs delivered healthy calves. He also cites being approached by owners who were otherwise planning to put down their disabled horses or camels.

Mathur says he is these days working on a prosthetic for the rear limb of a camel near Jodhpur. The owner, Ghasi Ram, is being trained to help the camel stand up with the support of ropes. "It's commendable how the owner had all this while been getting the camel to stand on three limbs," says Mathur. Not all efforts pay off, such as the failed attempt to get braces for an injured bird. But Mathur strives on. Inspired, his wife Shipra has left her teaching job and joined him. ■

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